In these circumstances, what is surely needed is an account of history that puts the Empire in its proper historical place which has been strangely lacking so far. In the words of Professor Edgerton, 'What's striking about postwar historiography is the lack of imperialist histories and the absence of condemnation for nationalist and anti-imperial forces.' And yet, as he explains, 'Putting the empire in its proper historical place is hugely important for understanding the sheer scale of slavery, the racialised nature of the imperial project . . .'[3] This is why at Oxford University there has been a successful movement to remove the statue of the colonialist, Sir Cecil Rhodes, who had once given his name to the apartheid country of Rhodesia in southern Africa. As Din-Kariuki has written, the movement, however, has always been about more than a statue. Its demands are about the 'official, public and permanent acknowledgment' of the university's involvement in colonialism and slavery. This would include such things as the immediate renaming of the Codrington Library at All Souls College; the immediate renaming of the Rhodes Scholarship and of Rhodes House. However, it would include also other positive measures such as a 'reparatory scholarship scheme for Southern Africans of African descent' at Oriel; the 'establishment of a review committee for the decolonisation of the curriculum'; a 'commitment to bringing Black British undergraduate student numbers in line with the British population'; a 'commitment to doubling the number of Black faculty' and an 'anti-racism and implicit bias training' for students and staff.[4]

So, we can do two things. First, we can start by rejecting the end of Empire in India as a story of high politics. The fact is that the Empire in India was fundamentally undermined and destabilized from below. Young radicals from across Asia used new technologies of the printing press and global travel to communicate and interact as never before. Witness the example of Ajit Singh, Bhagat Singh's uncle, who went to Latin America and from there communicated with Har Dayal's Ghadar Party in San Francisco in 1918 before meeting with Subhas Chandra Bose in Europe in 1939, as the Second World War raged on. As clandestine networks spanned across the world's imperial metropolises, from London to Paris to the